

Unit 2 Guided Notes — Exponent Rules

Same base? Move the exponents.

Standards: NC.8.EE.1

This packet weaves three parts together: **Guided Notes** with worked examples, **Practice** built into each section to try as you learn, and a **Cumulative Review** with a full **Answer Key** at the end. Fill in the blanks and show your work on your printed copy.

Topics Covered: 2.1 Exponent Rules — Product, Quotient, Power, Zero, Negative (NC.8.EE.1)

⚠ **Parentheses come first!** A power attaches only to what it touches. $-3^2 = -9$, but $(-3)^2 = 9$. And a power outside parentheses hits EVERYTHING inside: $(3x^2)^3 = 27x^6$ (the 3 is cubed too). Keep an eye on parentheses all unit long.

1 Product & Quotient Rules

➤ **KEY RULE:** Exponent rules only apply when the BASES are the SAME!

Fill the examples and key phrases on your printed copy.

Rule	Formula	Simple Example	Monomial Example	Key Phrase
Product Rule	$x^a \times x^b = x^{a+b}$	_____	_____	_____
Quotient Rule	$x^a \div x^b = x^{a-b}$	_____	_____	_____

PRODUCT RULE: COUNT THE FACTORS

$$\begin{array}{c} \boxed{x} \boxed{x} \boxed{x} \\ x^3 \text{ (3 factors)} \end{array} \times \begin{array}{c} \boxed{x} \boxed{x} \\ x^2 \text{ (2)} \end{array} = \begin{array}{c} \boxed{x} \boxed{x} \boxed{x} \boxed{x} \boxed{x} \\ x^5 \text{ (5 factors)} \end{array}$$

$$x^3 \times x^2 = x^{3+2} = x^5 \rightarrow \text{ADD the exponents}$$

See WHY

$$\text{Product Rule} \cdot x^3 \times x^2 = x^5$$

$$\text{See why} \rightarrow \boxed{x} \boxed{x} \boxed{x} \times \boxed{x} \boxed{x} = \boxed{x} \boxed{x} \boxed{x} \boxed{x} \boxed{x} = x^5$$

Count the factors: $3 + 2 = 5$. Same base $\rightarrow$ ADD the exponents.

$$\text{Quotient Rule} \cdot x^5 \div x^2 = x^3$$

$$\text{See why} \rightarrow \boxed{x} \boxed{x} \boxed{x} \boxed{x} \boxed{x} \div \boxed{x} \boxed{x} \rightarrow \text{cancel 2 pairs} \rightarrow \boxed{x} \boxed{x} \boxed{x} = x^3$$

Cancel matching factors: $5 - 2 = 3$. Same base $\rightarrow$ SUBTRACT the exponents.

Quick Check

MC Simplify $x^5 \cdot x^3$. Which rule applies, and what is the result?

☐ Product Rule $\rightarrow x^8$ ☐ Power Rule $\rightarrow x^{15}$ ☐ Quotient Rule $\rightarrow x^2$

Worked Example — Simplify $(4x^3y^2)(3x^5y)$

Step 1 — Multiply coefficients: $4 \times 3 = 12$

Step 2 — Add x exponents: $x^3 \cdot x^5 = x^8$

Step 3 — Add y exponents: $y^2 \cdot y^1 = y^3$

✓ **Step 4 — Combine:** $12x^8y^3$

PRACTICE 1 Product & Quotient

Rules: Multiply → ADD exponents · Divide → SUBTRACT. Write each quotient as a reduced fraction. **Show your work in the box.**

1

Simplify $x^4 \cdot x^7$

2

Simplify $(3x^2)(5x^6)$

3

Simplify $(2a^3b^2)(4a^2b^5)$

4

Simplify $(-3x^4y)(6xy^3)$

5

Simplify $(5m^2n)(2mn^3)(3n^2)$

6

Simplify $\frac{x^9}{x^4}$

7

Simplify $\frac{15a^7}{3a^2}$

8

Simplify $\frac{24x^5y^6}{6x^2y^2}$

9

Simplify $\frac{20m^8n^3}{5m^3n}$

10

Simplify $\frac{-18p^6q^5}{3p^2q^2}$

11

Simplify $\frac{(2x^3)(6x^4)}{4x^2}$

12

Simplify $\frac{(3a^2b)(4a^3b^2)}{6ab}$

2 Power Rules

A power outside parentheses applies to every factor inside. Fill in, then check.

Rule	Formula	Simple Example	Monomial Example	Key Phrase
Power Rule	$(x^a)^b = x^{a \times b}$	_____	_____	_____
Power of a Product	$(xy)^n = x^n y^n$	_____	_____	_____
Power of a Quotient	$(\frac{x}{y})^n = \frac{x^n}{y^n}$	_____	_____	_____

⚠ PARENTHESES MATTER!

$-3^2 =$ _____ vs. $(-3)^2 =$ _____

Without (), ONLY the base gets the exponent — not the negative sign!

See WHY

Power Rule · $(x^2)^3 = x^6$

See why → $x^2 \cdot x^2 \cdot x^2 = x \cdot x \cdot x \cdot x \cdot x \cdot x = x^6$

Three copies of x^2 : $2 \times 3 = 6$. Power to a power → MULTIPLY.

ERROR ANALYSIS Spot the Error — Simplify $(3x^2)^3$. A student wrote $3x^6$.

The coefficient 3 must ALSO be cubed: $3^3 = 27$. Correct: $27x^6$. The power rule applies to EVERYTHING inside the parentheses.

Worked Example — Simplify $(2a^3b)^4$

Step 1 — Power the coefficient: $2^4 = 16$

Step 2 — Multiply the a exponent: $a^{3 \times 4} = a^{12}$

Step 3 — Multiply the b exponent: $b^{1 \times 4} = b^4$

✓ **Step 4 — Combine:** $16a^{12}b^4$

PRACTICE 2 Power Rules

Rule: Power to a power → MULTIPLY; apply the power to EVERY factor, top and bottom.

1

Simplify $(x^4)^5$

2

Simplify $(2x^3)^4$

3

Simplify $(-3a^2)^3$

4

Simplify $(x^2y^5)^3$

5

Simplify $(4m^3n^2)^2$

7

Simplify $(\frac{x^2}{y^3})^4$

9

Simplify $(\frac{3x^4}{2y})^2$

11

Simplify $(2x^2y)^3(3xy^2)^2$

6

Simplify $(2x^3y^4)^5$

8

Simplify $(\frac{2a}{b^2})^3$

10

Simplify $((x^3)^2)^4$

12

Simplify $(-2a^3b^2)^4$

3 Zero & Negative Exponents

Anything to the 0 power is 1; a negative exponent flips to a fraction.

Rule	Formula	Simple Example	Monomial Example	Key Phrase
Zero Exponent	$x^0 = 1$	_____	_____	_____
Negative Exponent	$x^{-n} = \frac{1}{x^n}$	_____	_____	_____

See WHY

Zero Exponent · $x^0 = 1$

See why → $x \cdot x \cdot x \div x \cdot x \cdot x = 1$, but by the quotient rule $= x^{3-3} = x^0$. So $x^0 = 1$

Anything (except 0) divided by itself is 1 → $x^0 = 1$.

Negative Exponent · $x^{-3} = \frac{1}{x^3}$

See why → $x \cdot x \div x \cdot x \cdot x \cdot x = x^{2-5} = x^{-3}$; cancelling leaves $\frac{1}{x^3}$

A negative exponent means 'flip it' → $x^{-n} = \frac{1}{x^n}$.

Match the Rule to its Key Phrase

MATCH Draw a line from each rule to its key phrase.

Rule

Product Rule

Quotient Rule

Power Rule

Negative Exponent

Key Phrase

Power to power? MULTIPLY

Same base? ADD exponents

Flip to a fraction

Same base? SUBTRACT exponents

Negative Exponents Across the Fraction Bar

A negative exponent moves its factor to the OTHER side of the bar and turns positive.

Move across the bar: $x^{-3} = \frac{1}{x^3} \cdot \frac{1}{x^{-3}} = x^3 \cdot \frac{x^{-2}}{y^{-4}} = \frac{y^4}{x^2}$

In parentheses — flip to the reciprocal: $(\frac{a}{b})^{-n} = (\frac{b}{a})^n$. $(\frac{2}{3})^{-2} = (\frac{3}{2})^2 = \frac{9}{4} \cdot (\frac{x^2}{y})^{-3} = (\frac{y}{x^2})^3 = \frac{y^3}{x^6}$

PRACTICE 3 Zero & Negative Exponents

Write every answer with POSITIVE exponents only, as a reduced fraction.

1

Simplify $(7x^4y^2)^0$

2

Simplify $(3a^2b)^0$

3

Evaluate 4^{-3}

4

Positive exponents: $2x^{-5}$

5

Simplify $\frac{x^{-3}}{y^{-2}}$

6

Simplify $\frac{a^{-2}b^3}{c^{-1}}$

7

Simplify $\frac{12m^{-2}n^4}{3m^4n^{-1}}$

8

Simplify $\frac{8x^{-3}y^2}{2xy^{-1}}$

9

Simplify $(\frac{x}{y})^{-2}$

11

Simplify $(\frac{a^2}{b})^{-3}$

10

Evaluate $(\frac{2}{3})^{-3}$

12

Simplify $(\frac{3x}{y^2})^{-2}$

★ Cumulative Practice — Unit 2 Review ★

Mixed practice over everything above. Show all work; circle your final answer.

REVIEW • A Exponent Rules

1

Simplify $x^4 \cdot x^6$

3

Simplify $(2a^3b^2)(5ab^4)$

5

Simplify $(m^3)^5$

7

Simplify $\frac{18a^5b^6}{3a^2b^2}$

2

Simplify $(3x^2)(4x^5)$

4

Simplify $\frac{24x^7}{6x^3}$

6

Simplify $(2x^2y^3)^4$

8

Simplify $(\frac{x^4}{y^2})^3$

REVIEW • B Negative Exponents & Rational Expressions

Write every answer with positive exponents only, as a reduced fraction.

1

Evaluate 5^{-2}

2

Positive exponents: $3x^{-4}$

3

Simplify $\frac{x^{-5}}{y^{-3}}$

4

Simplify $(\frac{a}{b})^{-3}$

5

Simplify $\frac{10a^{-2}b^5}{2a^3b^{-1}}$

6

Simplify $(\frac{2x^2}{y})^{-2}$